DIRECTORATE
MAHARASHTRA
TOURISM


PRATAPGAD

MAJESTIC STRONGHOLDS

EXPLORING THE HISTORIC FORTS OF MAHARASHTRA

Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj, a seminal figure in Indian history, is celebrated for his resistance against the Mughals and his vision of Hindavi Swaraj, or self-governance. Central to his military strategy was an extensive network of forts across Maharashtra, strategically placed on hilltops, coastlines, and inland areas. These forts were crucial for defense, administration, and training, facilitating prolonged sieges, guerrilla warfare, and efficient communication throughout the Maratha Empire. Notable examples include Raigad, the empire's capital, and Sinhagad, famed for its heroic battles. These forts were not merely military installations; they were vibrant centers of socio-political and cultural activity, hosting palaces, temples, and reservoirs.

Maharashtra boasts around 350 forts, each offering a unique glimpse into Maratha history. Here are some must-visit forts for history enthusiasts and architecture lovers:

HARISHCHANDRAGAD FORT

Ahmednagar

Harishchandragad, a renowned trekking destination, dates back to the 6th century under the Kalchuri dynasty. Located in Ahmednagar, the fort features ancient caves with idols of Lord Vishnu and holds cultural significance with references in the Matsyapurana and Agnipurana. Key attractions include Saptatirtha, Kedareshwar, and Taramati Peak.

How to go: Road: Mumbai – 201.8 km | Rail: Igatpuri – 41 km

Nearby Sights: Malshej Ghat, Naneghat Hills, Amruteshwar Temple, Pimpalgaon Joga Dam, Girijatmaka Temple, Ratangad Fort, Bhairavgadh, Kalu Water Fall.

RATANGAD FORT

Ahmednagar

Ratangad Fort, situated in the Western Ghats, is famous for its natural rock peak with a cavity known as "Nedhe" or "eye of the needle." The fort, with its four gates—Ganesh, Hanuman, Trimbak, and Konkan—offers stunning views and reflects ancient architecture. Captured by Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj from the Mughals, it remains one of his favorites.

How to go: Road: Mumbai – 177.2 km | Rail: Igatpuri – 56 km

Nearby Sights: Kalsubai Peak, Radha Falls, Bhandardara, Wilson Dam and Arthur Lake, Amruteshwar.

GAWILGAD FORT

Amravati

Near Chikhaldara hill station, Gawilgad Fort features Persian inscriptions and two water tanks, Devtalav and Khantalav. The fort's legends, including its association with the Gavli community, add to its mystique.

How to go: Road: Mumbai – 694.1 km | Rail: Badnera – 95 km

Nearby Sights: Bhimkund Point, Chikhaldara Hill Station, Panchbol Point, Shakkar Lake, Sunset Point, Shri Ambadevi Temple, Amravati, Mozari Point, Rukmani


RAIGAD



"The forts which dot the landscape of Maharashtra, from the Sahyadri mountain ranges to the coastal region play in preserving the rich historical legacy and attracting tourists from across the globe. They are not merely remnants of the past; they are vibrant symbols of Maharashtra's cultural heritage and a testament to the valor and architectural prowess of bygone eras. Our government is commited to revitalizing and promoting these historical structures, to provide an immersive experience for visitors eager to explore the narratives etched into their walls. We plan to enhance accessibility to these forts through improved infrastructure and organized tours that would enlighten tourists about the historical significance and support local economies. By investing in preservation efforts and marketing campaigns, we will do justice to our state as a premier destination for heritage tourism, fostering a deeper appreciation for the unique stories of resistance, triumph, and craftsmanship that these forts embody. Exploration of our forts is nothing short of a journey through time, a way to relive the pride of our illustrious past".

GIRISH MAHAJAN, Minister Of Tourism, Government Of Maharashtra